The Marvel Way

Final Report

The Origin Story

Marvel, the most recognizable comic book publishing company behind some of the most iconic superheroes and villains, from *Spider-Man* to the *X-Men*, to *Doctor Doom, Thanos* the *Avengers* and so many more. Throughout its history, which began in 1939 by publisher Martin Goodman under the name *Timely Comics*, there have been countless artists and writers who have stamped their name among *Marvel's* greats. *Marvel* legends such as writer Stan Lee and artist/writer Jack Kirby stand out amongst this endless list, as they are considered the founding fathers of the *Marvel*, comic book enthusiasts have come to know and love. Other dynamic names such as artists Todd McFarland and Steve Ditko also come to mind when discussing *Marvel's* best.

The collaboration between these artists and writers has given way to the most dynamic storylines and artwork to ever breech the comic world. The *Marvel Comics* dataset is intended to give insight into which writer/s and penciler/s have collaborated the most, how many comic issues they have produced together and the duration of these comic issues. Based on these same metrics I also take a look at which solo writers/pencilers have had the biggest impact within *Marvel's* existence.

By analyzing both the formidable alliances and solo work of writers and pencilers, entertainment executives can make more informed decisions about which writers and pencilers have created the most successful comic books based on how many issues they have collaborated on, the duration of the series and how many times they have collaborated.

Business Impact

The analysis of the *Marvel Comics* dataset could help entertainment executives:

- Identify which writer and penciler collaborations form the most elite team based on number of comic issues published together and the duration of each comic series.
- Which solo writer/pencilers have the most issue count and longest duration.
- Which comic series has had the most success based on the duration of the issue.

Overall, the analysis of the Marvel Comics Dataset is an attempt to give entertainment executives better insight to which writer/penciler collaborations or solo work will generate the most successful comic issues.

Dataset Information

File Name:	Marvel Comics.csv
Description:	The dataset contains info on all the comic books ever released in the Marvel Universe.
Dataset Details:	34993 Rows and 12 Columns
Size:	13.62MB
Source:	Kaggle

Data Profiling

- The original *Marvel Comics* dataset consisted of a total of 12 columns and 34,993 rows. The original columns were as follows in exact order: Comic Name, Issue Title, Publish Date, Issue Description, Penciler, Writer, Cover Artist, Imprint, Format, Rating, Price.
- Determine which of these columns will be most useful based on my thesis, which is to verify which *Marvel* comics where the most successful based on number of writer/penciler collaborations, solo work and duration of those specific comics and limit to top 15.
- Identify which columns are numeric, text, or date/year fields.
- Find and eliminate duplicate penciler/writer names.

Data Wrangling

Original *Marvel Comics* dataset:

Column Name	Number of Null Values	Action Made	Reason

Comic Name	0	Filtered	Unnecessary
Active Years	34978	Filtered	Unnecessary
Issue Title	0	Filtered	No action needed
Publish Date	33909	Filtered	Unnecessary
Issue Description	8	Filtered	Unnecessary
Penciler	0	Filtered	No action needed
Writer	0	Filtered	No action needed
Cover Artist	0	Filtered	No action needed
Imprint	12	Filtered	Unnecessary
Format	0	Filtered	No action needed
Rating	0	Filtered	No action needed
Price	32880	Filtered	Unnecessary

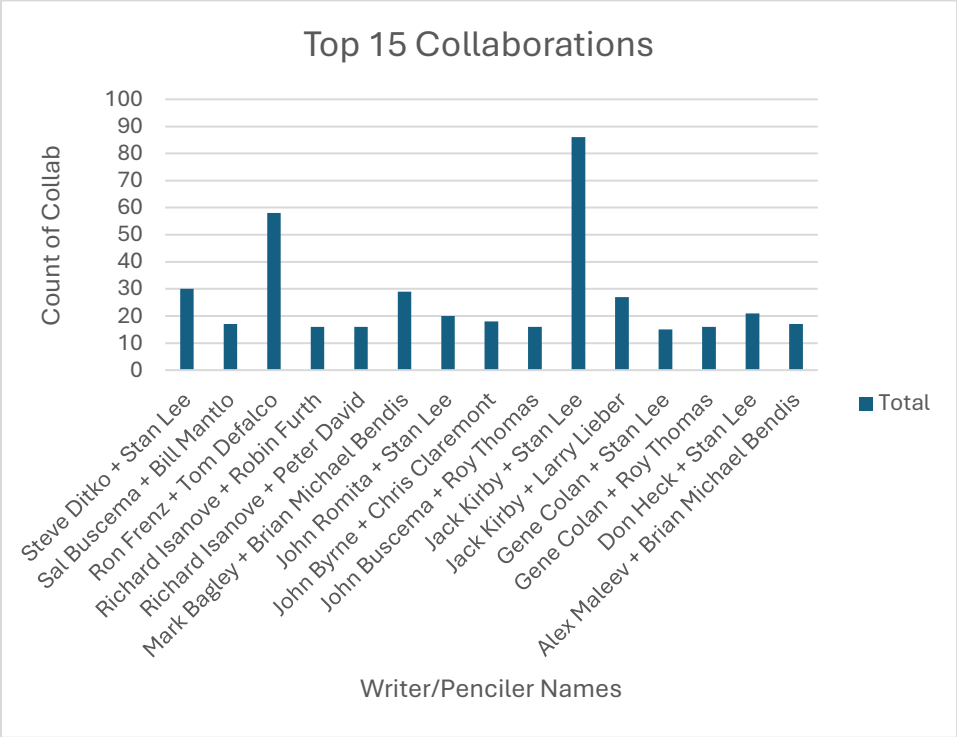
Cleaned *Marvel Comics* dataset

Column Name	Description	Purpose
Issue Title	Name of Comic/series	Longest duration/Most collabs
Penciler	Name of artist aka Penciler	who penciled the comic
Writer	Name of writer	Who wrote the comic
Collaboration	Name of writer/penciler	Total # of collabs
Active years Start	When comic began	To find its duration
Active years End	When comic ended	To find its duration
Total years	Total # of collab years	To find longest colllabs/solo
Collab vs Solo	Collabs vs solo work	Most/longest collabs and Most/longest solo work

Data Analysis

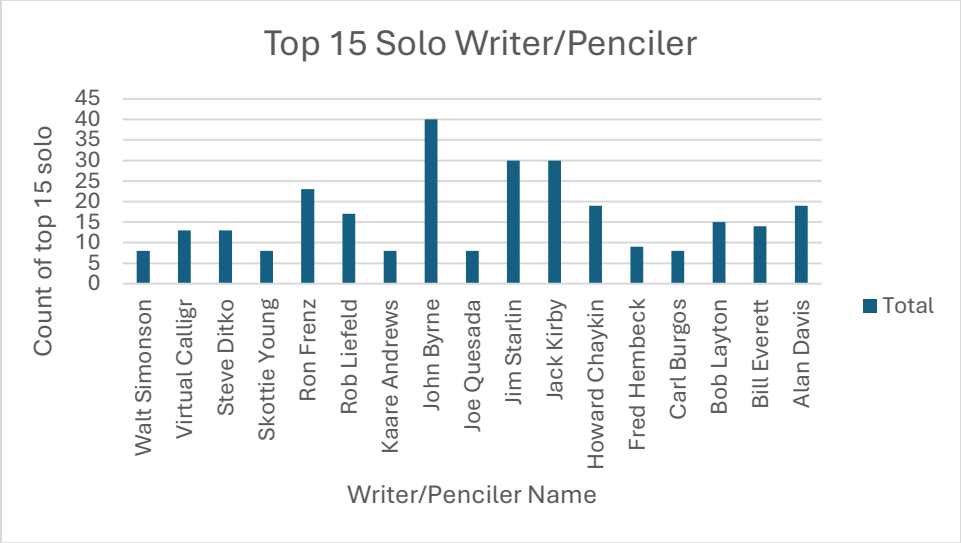
1. *Top 15 Writer/Penciler Collaborations*

Artist/writer Jack Kirby and writer/publisher Stan Lee stand out as having the most collaborations, with a whopping 86 collabs, as seen in the bar chart below, created in excel. Ron Frenz and Tom Defalco also deserve an honorable mention with 58 total collaborations.



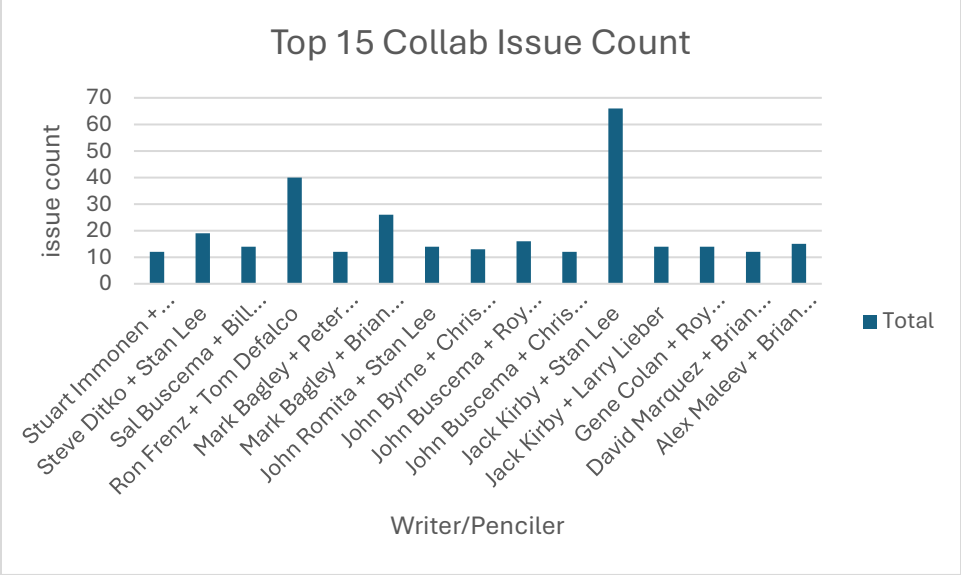
2. Top 15 Solo writer/pencil work

John Byrne sits atop this list, doing solo work on comics 40 times, as seen in the bar chart below. Jim Starlin and Jack Kirby worked solo for a total of 30 times.



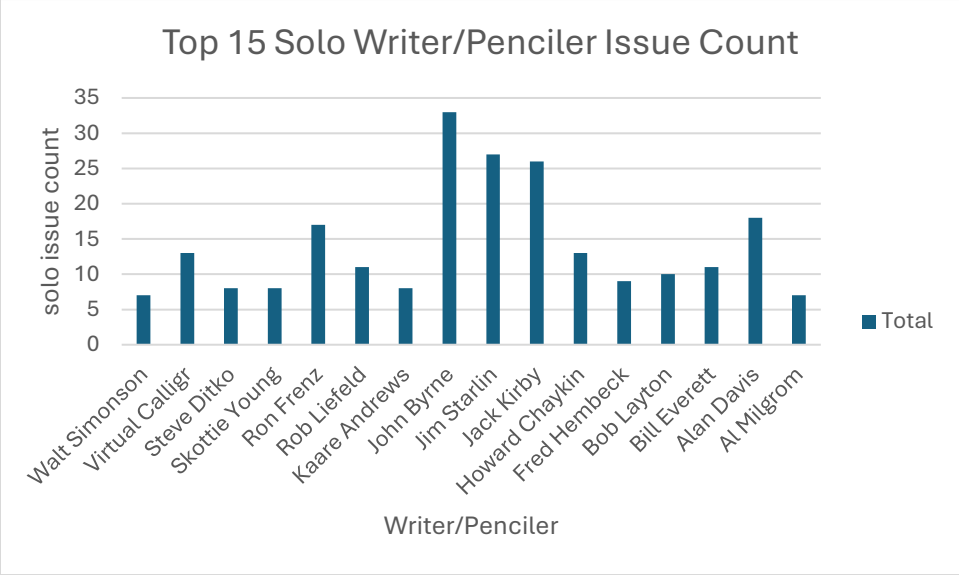
3. Top 15 writer/penciler Collab Issue Count

Stan Lee and Jack Kirby have the most comic issues collaborated on with an issue count of 66. Ron Frenz and Tom Defalco have the second most issues collaborated on with an issue count of 40.



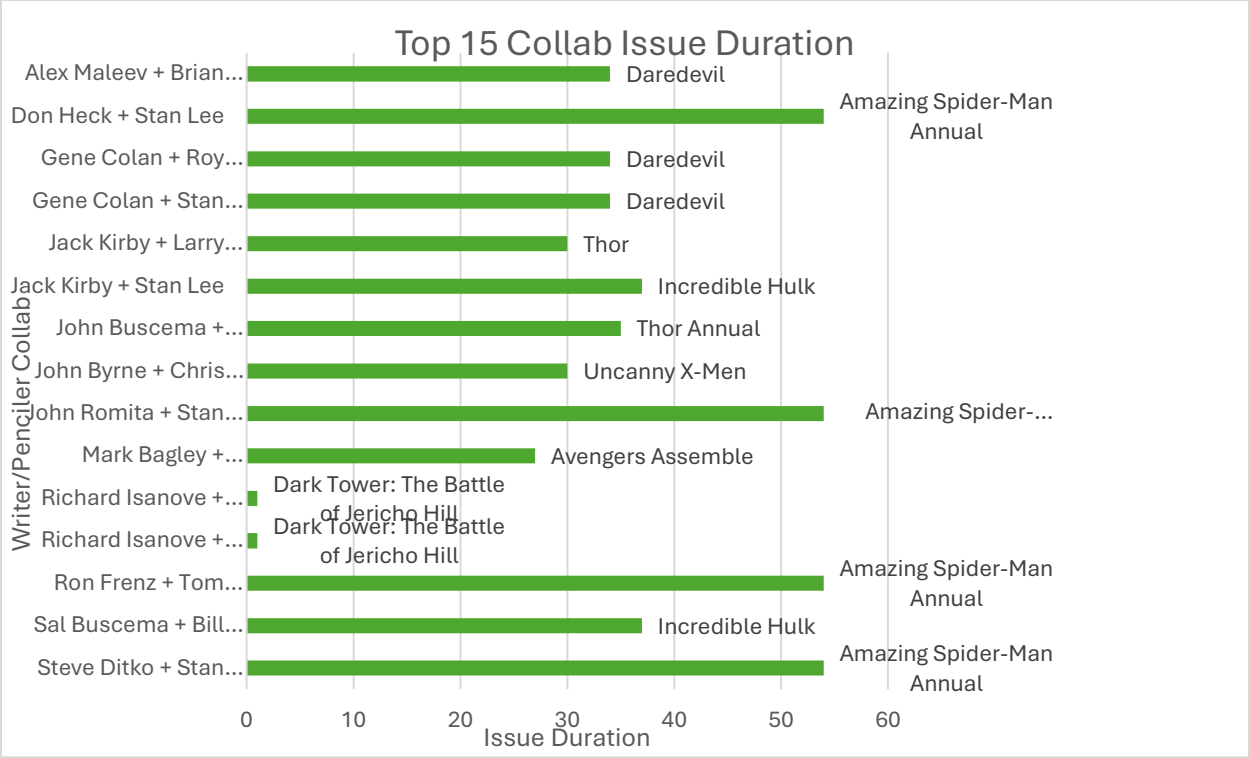
4. Top 15 Solo writer/penciler Issue Count

   John Byrne has done solo work a total of 33 times, standing out among solo comic writer/pencilers. Jim Starlin have the second most at 27 times and Jack Kirby at 26 times



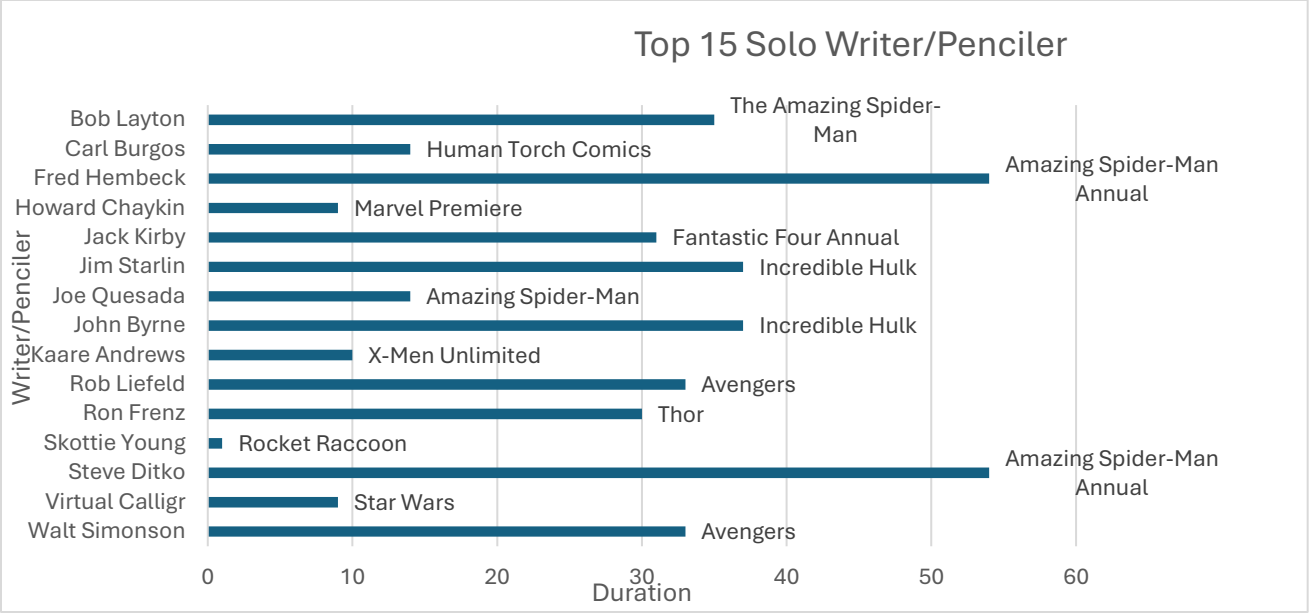
5. Top 15 Collab Issue Duration

   The *Amazing Spider-Man Annual* has the longest active duration at a staggering 54 years. Considered one of the most iconic series in *Marvel's* history Stan Lee, Ron Frenz, Don Heck, John Romita, Tom Defalco and Steve Ditko have all left their imprint on this series throughout this 54 year span. The *Incredible Hulk* has the second longest duration at 37 years, also one of *Marvel's* most recognizable comic series.



6. Top 15 Solo Issue Duration

The *Amazing Spider-Man Annual* also has the longest duration of solo work, again at 54 years. In addition to the aforementioned writers/pencilers in # 5, Fred Hembeck also did work on this series over the span of this issue duration. Along with Jack Kirby and Stan Lee, Jim Starlin and John Byrne also did solo work on the *Incredible Hulk* over the series 37-year span.



Challenges and Solutions

One of the challenges faced when working with the *Marvel Comics* dataset is that the original dataset did not clearly show the longest comic series duration, only showing originally how long an issue lasted. For example, *Daring Comics* 1940-1942 issue #12, which only indicates how long that specific issue ran which in this case for 2 years. I wanted to find the longest active comic series.

Since I wanted to find the total # of collaborations, the original dataset showed who the writer/penciler collaborations were but did not give the total # of collaborations between each writer/penciler. First, I created a column that gave both writer/penciler collaborations utilizing the Text Join/Trim functions in excel. The original dataset had numerous duplicate writer/penciler names, potentially indicating that the individual did solo work on a comic, both writing and penciling. I proceeded to eliminate these duplicates to prevent these solo names being counted as a collaboration and to prevent these solo names being counted multiple times, skewing the end outcomes. I then created a column Solo vs. Collab using the IF function in excel.

After organizing collaborations vs solo work, I used the IF, LEN, FIND, LEFT and MID functions to find specific names of writer/penciler collaborations and the total # these writer/pencilers collaborated. I did the same process to find the Solo writer/pencilers and their count.

Overall, I found these tasks the most challenging, utilizing the correct excel formulas to find the specific information needed in my cleaned dataset.

Conclusion

Clearly Stan Lee, Jack Kirby, John Byrne, Steve Ditko, Ron Frenz, Tom Defalco and issue titles such as *The Amazing Spider-Man* and *The Incredible Hulk* stand out as the most dynamic writer/penciler pairings and comic series *Marvel* has witnessed.

Despite the weight carried by these names and titles, it should be understood that certain writers/pencilers may have a level of familiarity with certain comic issues, as pencilers/writers may be known for a specific work/s. These specific pairings may better understand the energy, vibe, personalities and overall lore needed for a specific comic book series.

Future Work

Going forward I would possibly like to take a look at how successful these comics were, not only based on the writer/penciler collabs/solo work, but how much revenue these comics generated. I would also like to take a look at how many times each comic series was brought to cinema into and compare that generated revenue to the comic book itself. I could also take a look at comics that did make the big screen and see how often, if any, they were remade as well as determine if the comic story itself was re-written.

Another analysis worth diving into is to determine which write/penciler collaborations saw their work brought to the big screen.

In all, the future work would be intended to help better describe which writer/penciler collaborations are the most successful, based on revenue generation and how often they saw their work on the big screen. This would help entertainment executives better determine how to make a successful comic book series and movie.